



RUSSIAN FEDERATION

Capital city: Moscow

Area: 6,592,735 sq miles
(17,075,200 sq km)

Population: 143,000,000

Official language:
Russian

Major religions: Russian Orthodox 75%, Muslim 10%, other 15%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Rouble

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 66 years

People per doctor: 238

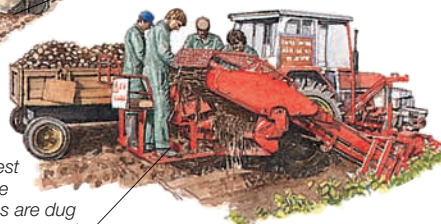
Televisions: 420 per 1,000 people

RUSSIAN FEDERATION

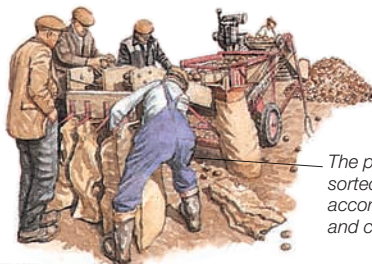
THE URAL MOUNTAINS form the boundary between European and Asian Russia. European Russia lies to the west of the mountains. This vast stretch of land is home to more than 100 million people, two-thirds of the entire Russian population. Most people live in the big cities of Moscow – the capital of the country – and St. Petersburg, or along the Volga River valley. The land is rich in minerals. It is also intensively farmed, with wheat and other grains in the north giving way to tobacco, citrus fruit, and a variety of crops in the warmer south.



Potatoes are grown on a huge scale in Russia. The large, open fields are plowed into furrows and then the potatoes are planted in neat rows by machine.



At harvest time, the potatoes are dug out of the ground.



The potatoes are sorted and graded according to size and condition.



ST. PETERSBURG

With its network of canals and rivers, the elegant city of St. Petersburg is known as the “Venice of the North.” It is a center for arts and culture and has many fine 18th-century buildings. It was the capital of Russia between 1713–1917. Under communist rule the city was renamed Leningrad to honor Lenin, the leader of the 1917 Russian revolution. With the collapse of communism in 1991, it reverted to its old name.



Most of Russia's crops are grown in “the fertile triangle,” which stretches from St. Petersburg and Ukraine in the west to southern Siberia in the east.

AGRICULTURE

Because of the harsh climate, only about 10 percent of Russian land is used for growing crops, mostly in an area known as the “fertile triangle” (see map right). The country is the world's leading producer of oats, and the second greatest producer of barley and potatoes. During the 1950s a vast area of barren land in south-central Russia was cultivated, the largest expansion of agriculture in the last 100 years. The new wheat fields freed up more fertile areas in the west to grow fodder for animals.



RUSSIAN BALLET

Ballet arrived in Russia from France in the 19th century thanks to close cultural and diplomatic ties between Paris and St. Petersburg, the old Russian capital. By the early 20th century, Russia had transformed traditional ballet, making it more creative and exciting. Today, the Bolshoi Ballet of Moscow and the Kirov Ballet of St. Petersburg are known throughout the world.

RELIGIOUS REVIVAL

The Russian Orthodox Church was suppressed for many years by the former Soviet government, but became legal once more with the ending of communism. Today churches and monasteries are reopening across the country, and many people regularly attend religious services. As Russian society continues to change rapidly, the unchanging traditions of the Orthodox Church are a great comfort to many people.

The head of the Russian Orthodox Church is known as the Patriarch of Moscow and All Russia.

